Answering 20-Mark Questions

Exam code: 9BS0

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Written by: Lisa Eades
Reviewed by: Steve Vorster
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How do I answer an Edexcel A level Business 20-mark question?

- These questions appear in all three exam papers
- Four marks are available for knowledge, four for application, six for analysis and six for evaluation
- These questions require you to make a recommendation between two choices or strategies
  - Your answer needs to weigh up both of the options presented, considering both benefits and drawbacks
  - Your recommendation needs to be wide-ranging and fully developed, considering reasons for your recommendation
  - You should also provide reasons why the alternative has been rejected

Help me understand

Suggested structure

- Key business skills are highlighted

Knowledge Application Analysis Evaluation

Step 1
• Start off by defining the key terms in the question stem, likely to be the two options   ○ This will secure some Level 1 knowledge marks and can help you focus your response
Cost competitiveness and differentiation are strategies identified by Michael Porter. Cost competitiveness involves having the lowest costs amongst competitors. Differentiation involves being distinctive by standing out from rivals on quality, innovation, brand identity or customer service. By adopting one or the other of these strategies mass market businesses such as Cadbury's can avoid being 'stuck in the middle'. Detailed knowledge, defining both of the key terms in the question Showing strong understanding

Stuck on something?
Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.
Got it

- In the next paragraph, you should start your analysis by making a strong point
  - Support it with some relevant context from the stimulus material
    - Quoting some data, including a calculation, or remarking on a key business feature or trend are good ways to do this
  - Develop a chain of reasoning that develops the point logically. The X→Y→Z approach is a good way to build a coherent chain:
    - E.g. X leads to Y which results in Z or X and Y lead to Z
  - The best chains of analysis combine points effectively. For example:
    - E.g. X_1 and X_2 lead to Y, which results in Z or X leads to Y_1 and/or Y_2, which results in Z or X leads to Y, which results in Z_1 and/or Z_2

Cadbury's is a long-established British chocolate manufacturing business. Its brands include Dairy Milk and Crème Egg. These products target the mass market but are high differentiated. Its brand names are highly-recognised, with some having existed for more than a hundred years. Packaging is distinctive and Cadbury's spends large amounts on promoting the products. It also innovates - products such as Oreo bars and Marvellous Creations have brought recent success. Continuing to differentiate on a global scale may therefore be the logical choice. Chocolate snacks could be adapted for different international markets. Cadbury's could use its expertise in branding and innovation to ensure products stand out from rivals'. This competitive advantage would reduce the risk of entering new markets.

Using the context to set the scene for this paragraph

Confident use of business key terms

Some judgement shown here

Strong chain of reasoning which develops the point effectively

Step 3

- In the next paragraph, make a second relevant point for the first option
- Again, ensure that you include some context from the stimulus material
- You need to develop a similarly complex and coherent chain of XYZ reasoning.

Additionally, Cadbury's has an excellent reputation for corporate social responsibility. The business was somewhat unique in providing housing for its factory workers in Birmingham. It also looked after them in retirement. More recently it has taken steps to make its products more healthy. It also demonstrates some commitment to implementing responsible supply chains. These unique features mean that Cadburys is in a good position to emphasise its differences from other manufacturers. This, again, suggests that a differentiation strategy may be more appropriate.

Appropriate use of the business context

Less developed analysis but leads to a judgement

Step 4

- Make sure that it remains relevant to the question stem
- A further chain of XYZ reasoning with context is also required

However Cadburys only currently sells its products in forty markets worldwide. To achieve global competitive advantage it will be looking to enter new markets. In these new locations its range of chocolate products will lack the level of recognition they enjoy in existing markets. Cadbury's benevolence towards workers in 19th Century Britain are unlikely to be relevant. Its move away from Fairtrade has led to a loss of credibility in terms of social responsibility. Cadbury's brands will have to compete with established brands in new markets. It is unlikely to be able to differentiate through advertising and branding initially. Innovation may also be tricky, as these are markets with which it has no prior experience. Extensive market research and product testing will be required. As a British brand it may be able to emphasise the quality of its products. Decisions such as the switch from raisins to cheaper sultanas suggests that this may not be realistic.

A really well-developed chain of reasoning, with lots of context

Some more judgement shown here

Step 5

- You now need to move on to the second option
- Support a strong opening point with some relevant context from the stimulus material using the X→Y→Z approach

Cost competitiveness may be a more suitable strategy to achieve global competitiveness. Cadbury's investment in 'state of the art' production facilities is expected to increase efficiency. Productivity may therefore be improved. As a result the costs involved in the manufacture of its products will be reduced. As well as this, Cadburys manufactures chocolate in ten different countries. There is a huge potential for economies of scale. Ingredients such as cocoa and sultanas can be purchased in vast quantities, minimising variable costs.

Clear knowledge

A really well-developed chain of reasoning, with lots of context

Step 6

- Make a second relevant point for the second option
- You may choose to use business theories or models to support your analysis

- Again, show balance by providing at least one counterargument for the second option
- Make a logical, relevant counterpoint
- Make sure that it remains relevant to the question stem
- Some reference to what the business wants to achieve in making the choice is a useful way to do this

Step 8

- In your final paragraphs, you need to make a **supported judgement**
  - This should be the **most developed section** of your response
  - Weigh up both of your arguments, considering their strength and relevance
  - Compare them directly, considering which might be most effective in meeting business objectives
  - A decision is required, along with the main reasons for your choice
    - Are there any context-specific reasons for your choice?
    - Do you have all of the information required to make a reliable recommendation?
    - Does your answer depend on any internal or external factors?
  - Try to **broaden your reflection** by considering factors such as whether your decision would be different in the long term, the views of different stakeholders, or the contribution your decision may make to achieving business aims and objectives
- The **MOPS approach** can be a useful way to frame your concluding paragraph
  - Consider the **market** in which the business is operating, its **objectives**, the **product** it offers, and **the situation** in which it finds itself
  - Are any of these factors of particular importance to the decision?
  - This approach encourages you to include further contextual information and can make the difference between low-level and high-level responses.

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